



game and more chances of tight finishes. For these situations, a captain needs to be mentally sharp. Rohit has often shown that he leads by instinct, which has worked very well for him, and now that all the questions about his place in the team have been hit for a massive six with that magnificent century, he will also lead with the weight of worrying for a place in the team off his shoulders.

The wins in the T20 series and the ODI series put India in a great place as far as confidence is concerned. There are only a couple of loose ends to be tied up, and that is Jasprit Bumrah's availability for the Champions Trophy and Virat Kohli getting back among the hundreds, as Rohit has done. Kohli is a big-match player, and nothing will motivate

Bouncing back: Rohit Sharma returned to form with a majestic 119 from 90 balls to power India towards victory in the second ODI against England in Cuttack. K. R. DEEPAK

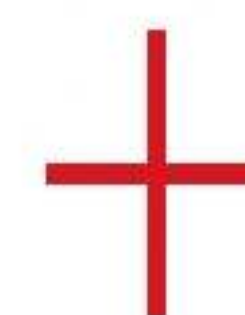
him more than the opportunity to score runs and win the Champions Trophy for India. After the last Champions Trophy win in 2013, he celebrated with the Gangnam dance, which was the rage way back then. If he helps India win this time, we could be in for another unique celebration from him.

It's been just over a month since Bumrah had his back issue in Sydney, and hopefully, he will be fit for the tournament. His presence almost guarantees wickets at the start and also in the final overs, apart from his miserly allowance of runs to the opposition batters. The pitch in Dubai will certainly be a little bouncer and, with it, have more carry than the ones India has played on in the recent series. That's why his presence is so vital for India's chances. Mohammed Shami's return to the team has also been most encouraging, and one can see that he is regaining his rhythm and pace.

The other heartening aspect of India's cricket in the series has been the outstanding catches taken by the fielders. Yes, there have been some simple catches floored too, but overall, the fielding has been top-class, with maybe just one fielder to hide. That, though, is a situation for all the teams in the world, where one of their bowlers is a weak link in the fielding unit. Good captains will see who is bowling and hide those fielders in positions where the ball is less likely to go.

The spirit in the team is very good, as could be seen by their enthusiastic cheering of their teammates who won individual awards at the recent annual BCCI awards function.

A team that is laughing with each other is a happy team that will invariably try and play for each other. That's why India, apart from the talent that they have, will start as the firm favourites to win the ICC Champions Trophy once again.



Virat Kohli is a big-match player, and nothing will motivate him more than the opportunity to score runs and win the Champions Trophy for India.